



OSLOMET · ACIT5910 · PROBLEM STATEMENT

Phishing Between Loneliness and Skepticism: How Social Engineering Exploits the Need for Belonging, Safety, and Control

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Problem

Phishing remains the dominant entry point to serious cyber incidents, yet technical controls and awareness campaigns have not eliminated it. In Norway, public skepticism toward unknown senders has increased, while loneliness is elevated among young adults and students (Statistics Norway, 2025; Khrono & Norwegian Student Organisation, 2024).

Research problem: Why does phishing remain effective when people are both more lonely and more skeptical, and which emotional and contextual factors make individuals in higher education especially vulnerable? The thesis introduces the skepticism paradox as its analytical lens.

Research question

Main RQ: How can phishing remain effective in a context of increased loneliness and increased general skepticism, and which emotional, cognitive, and contextual factors make individuals especially vulnerable to social engineering?

Hypotheses: H1 loneliness and social lures; H2 skepticism × lure type interaction; H3 situational mediation; H4 protective factors (PMT).

Method (planned)

Element	Plan
Design	Exploratory sequential mixed methods
Sample	120-180 survey + 12-18 interviews; HE in Norway, 18+
Instruments	UCLA loneliness (short form), skepticism scale, scenarios S1-S6, interviews
Ethics	NSD/REK before Phase 2 data collection

Contribution

- Human-centred model linking loneliness, skepticism, and lure type.
- Empirical insight for Norwegian higher education security culture.
- Feasible ACIT long thesis scope without classified infrastructure access.

Timeline

Phase 1 (ACIT5910): literature and plan · Phase 2 (ACIT5920): data collection · Phase 3 (ACIT5930): analysis and submission (2027).